

Serpentine FAE Fellowship — FINAL FORM ANSWERS (paste sheet)

****Spine:** Personal computing is being re-constituted by AI convergence — pulled into the data center, dissolved into a thin client — and Aesthetic Computer is the divergent counter-move: a creative-computing *commons* and a bare-metal *creative* OS that re-founds the personal computer as something owned and played in common, on surplus hardware, in the lineage of the Princeton Laptop Orchestra, UbuWeb, and the public library. LLMs are both the enclosing force and the faculty AC is uniquely poised to metabolize locally, on its own terms.** Genuinely on FAE's theme (convergence = systems interpenetrating + mutual re-constitution, agentic AI as accelerant; art as divergence; an active site of instability — "the personal computer" itself).

Mapped field-by-field to the live Airtable form; word counts in [N words] .

Deadline 2026-06-07, midnight BST. Form:

<https://airtable.com/appB9uhkcEZ0NUpbQ/pagB33PwCFgLTUTww/form>

(confirm) = your decision before submitting.

Personal details

Full Name: Jeffrey Alan Scudder **Email Address:** mail@aesthetic.computer **Primary Residence:** Los Angeles, California, USA **Website or Online Presence:** <https://aesthetic.computer> **Are you applying as an individual or a collective?** Individual

Overview of your practice or profession (100 words max)

Painter and toolmaker in Los Angeles. For six years I have built Aesthetic Computer — a runtime, an operating system, and a social network for creative computing — and given it away as a commons people make and run their work on rather than rent. You make pieces in JavaScript or KidLisp, alongside paintings, tapes, and chats, and a surplus laptop boots into the whole thing in about seven seconds with AC Native OS. I build the tools I make my own work with, in public. No Paint and notepad have both reached the front page of Hacker News.

[97 words — under the 100 cap · ~grade 10]

Core research question (one line)

As AI pulls computing into the data center, the personal computer is becoming a thin client. What would it take to re-found it instead as a creative commons — a bare-metal OS, shared languages and media, and an ensemble of surplus laptops a community owns and plays together?

Fellowship Proposal (500 words max — context · what's at stake & why now · connection to Art × Convergence)

Personal computing is being remade in front of us. As demand for AI compute pulls everything toward the data center, the personal computer is turning into a thin client — a window onto someone else's machine, rented by the month. The consumer operating system already keeps your identity in a cloud account, finishing the job. That is convergence as you mean it: two systems once held apart, now overlapping and remaking each other, with agentic AI as the accelerant.

Home computing needs a revolution at the operating-system layer — not another app, but a different ground to stand on. I have spent six years writing software and patterning for one.

Aesthetic Computer is a creative-computing commons. You make pieces in JavaScript or in KidLisp, a tiny language built for it, and the same system holds paintings, tapes, chats, and other media — all of it living at web addresses anyone can open. Around that sit a social layer and a papermill. Underneath is AC Native OS, a bare-metal Linux that boots any surplus laptop into the instrument in about seven seconds, with your identity in the boot partition, not a cloud login. The machine greets you by name, and a retired fifty-dollar ThinkPad becomes a personal instrument you own outright.

It is also a laptop-orchestra argument. In 2005 the Princeton Laptop Orchestra proved a room of networked laptops could be a real instrument, but at fifteen hundred dollars a seat it stayed locked inside wealthy universities. AC Native OS drops that cost by two orders of magnitude. On the hardware the upgrade cycle throws away, that orchestra can become planetary, and held in common.

Here is what is at stake: if the personal computer becomes a terminal, the most basic site of creative freedom — a machine you own and can read all the way down — gets shut away. The genuinely unstable category is the personal computer itself: is it still yours, or has it become a thin client? That is an art question as much as a technical one, and I would rather stay inside it than resolve it early.

What I most want to push on is what language models change. They are what pulls computing into the data center, but they are also the reason one artist and a small community can now build and tend a whole operating system that once took a company. I already let agents into Aesthetic Computer on its own terms — running locally, governed by the commons, never routed through a data center. The real question is whether a creative OS can take language models in as local, owned faculties, ones that make a personal computer more capable without turning it into a tenant of the cloud. I think Aesthetic Computer can answer it, because it already holds the whole stack, from kernel to community.

That is the divergence I am after: to branch away from the data-center default and re-found the personal computer as something we own in common.

[500 words — at the cap · ~grade 11]

Six-month R&D plan (500 words max — methods/tools/dependencies · support wanted from Serpentine · documentation)

I have already built the system. The six months are for pushing it to where convergence actually bites — turning Aesthetic Computer into a creative OS and commons that re-founds personal computing instead of renting it — and writing down how it goes. Three threads, paced to the London weekends.

Harden the OS into a real personal computer (*Sep–Nov*). I want to make AC Native OS something you would use every day on a surplus laptop: the boot-to-instrument path, identity stored in the device, over-the-air updates, and a clear written account of what a home computer even is when you own it and can read it all the way down. The measure is simple — more people booting throwaway machines into the commons.

LLMs as local faculties, not landlords (*Nov–Jan*). This is the live question, and the riskiest part. I want to prototype letting agentic AI into the OS on its own terms, running locally where it can, governed by the commons, and never phoning home to the data center, and then ask what a model can make a personal computer capable of without turning it into a tenant. This is what I most want the cohort to argue with me about.

Grow the laptop orchestra (*Jan–Mar*). This thread takes the laptop orchestra off the university campus: a shared language, shared instruments, and surplus hardware, played together, starting with the NELA Computer Club here in Los Angeles. I will harden KidLisp into a dependable standard and keep the archive from rotting, so that an ensemble can rely on it.

I am honest about the catch. Local AI on a fifty-dollar laptop is a real constraint, and "where it can" is doing a lot of work there. If the models will not fit, the finding — how far a personal computer carries on its own before it has to call out — is worth publishing on its own.

Tools: the AC kernel, runtime, KidLisp, and AC Native OS, along with local model integration, content-addressing for permanence, and the papermill for documentation. The work is iterative and done in the open.

What I would want from Serpentine:

- Cohort and panel critique on the core question — local faculties versus data-center enclosure.
- FAE's own cultural-infrastructure research as a sparring partner, with AC in direct conversation with it.
- Introductions to other people maintaining independent operating systems, runtimes, and archives — nobody talks about this, and everybody is stuck on it.
- A real audience for the documentation while it is being made, not after.

Documentation: Aesthetic Computer already publishes everything — source, papers, and daily editions, with the OS and laptop-orchestra papers already public. I will run this the same way: a public work-log, the OS and language references out in the open, and a written piece for FAE on re-founding personal computing as a commons. The low-residency shape fits, since I can build between the weekly sessions and use the three weekends as milestones.

[498 words — under the 500 cap · ~grade 11]

What has most influenced the trajectory of your practice or profession? (200 words max)

Two things have shaped the work, and they pull against each other.

Painting came first. I trained as a painter at Ringling and then Yale, and never left it. The immediacy of a mark on a surface is still the standard everything else answers to. My digital work began as an attempt to make software feel that immediate, and that became Radical Digital Painting — the paint program treated as a medium, not a utility, performed live.

Then came the realisation that the tool itself is the work. Touring Europe performing drawing with Goodiepal & Pals, and years of teaching at UCLA, Parsons, and Southern Oregon, convinced me that handing someone an instrument changes more than handing them an image. So I stopped renting

my tools and built my own in public — first No Paint, then Aesthetic Computer.

The throughline is ownership and immediacy together — the whole stack in hand, from gesture to kernel. What has changed lately is the stakes: once other people make and keep their work on what you have built, it becomes a commons, and as computing gets pulled into the data center, holding onto a computer you actually own stops being a preference and becomes worth defending.

[200 words — at the cap · ~grade 10]

What do you want to enable for others through your practice? (200 words max)

I want more people to own a computer they can read, and to hold it in common — treating the operating system, the languages, and the place their work lives as shared material they tend, not platforms they rent.

That is what Aesthetic Computer is for. You write pieces in JavaScript or KidLisp, and they live at web addresses anyone can open, alongside the paintings, tapes, and chats people make. The whole system boots from a single file on a USB stick, so the cost of entry is nearly zero — a fifty-dollar surplus laptop the upgrade cycle threw out. The Princeton Laptop Orchestra proved laptops could be a real ensemble, then stayed locked inside wealthy universities, and I want it planetary instead, and held in common.

What I most want to leave behind is durable independence. Not just that people can build their own substrate, but that it lasts — that a community can depend on it, that a piece still runs in ten years, and that the knowledge of how to keep it alive is written down and shared. I would rather hand over a living commons and a method anyone can repeat than a sealed artwork. Agency that endures.

[200 words — at the cap · ~grade 10]

AI tool disclosure (Yes / No — if yes, 50 words max)

Yes. I used Claude (Anthropic) to help organise and tighten these answers against the form's prompts and word limits. The research question, the plan, the practice, and every decision are my own — the AI helped with structure and editing, not with the underlying ideas.

[44 words]

Attendance confirmation (select all that apply)

☒ Select **all** — the three London weekends + weekly online + independent + cohort sessions:

- Wed 16 – Sun 20 Sep 2026 (Kickoff) · Wed 11 – Sun 15 Nov 2026 (Midpoint) · Wed 10 – Sun 14 Mar 2027 (Closing)

⟨confirm⟩ After your Spring-2026 UCLA residency ends, so no clash there — but check the three windows against NELA rhythm + any Fia/travel plans.

Visa support

No. (US passport holder; visitor allowance covers the intensives.) ⟨confirm⟩ if status differs.

Access needs / support structures (optional)

Leave blank, or: "Travelling from Los Angeles for each intensive; covered travel + accommodation makes the three trips workable."

References (two — name, role/organisation, email, relationship) — LOCKED 2026-06-04

A reference is lighter than a written letter (they may simply be contacted).

1. **Casey Reas** — artist; Professor, UCLA Design Media Arts; host of the Social Software residency Jeffrey is currently in. Relationship: residency host / peer. ⟨add email⟩
2. **Julia Yerger** — collaborator (Radical Digital Painting; Johannes Vogt gallery show). Relationship: collaborator. ⟨add email⟩

Uploads

CV (PDF): papers.aesthetic.computer/jeffrey-alan-scudder-cv.pdf (exists) — upload, or export [papers/cv/cv.pdf](#). Portfolio (single PDF, ≤10pp, ≤20MB): needs assembling. (I can build it from CV + AC/OS screenshots.) Video Introduction (≤3 min): see the dedicated mock — [VIDEO-MOCK.md](#) + [recap/audience/serpentine.mjs](#).

Work samples — captions ready (60 words max each); fill links <add links>

1. **Aesthetic Computer (the system / a KidLisp piece)** — 2020– · <https://aesthetic.computer> · author Caption: A runtime, OS, and social network where artists make pieces in JavaScript or KidLisp, alongside paintings, tapes, and chats — each living at a shareable web address. Open one and it boots on a refurbished laptop. The cultural commons the proposal sets out to re-found and sustain. [47 words]
2. **AC Native OS (re-founding the personal computer)** — *AC Native OS, 2025–* · <clip URL> · author Caption: A bare-metal OS that boots any surplus laptop into a creative instrument in about seven seconds, with your identity living in the boot partition rather than a platform login. It re-founds the personal computer as something owned and held in common, and makes a planetary laptop orchestra affordable. [50 words]
3. **notepat (instrument)** — 2024 · <https://aesthetic.computer/notepat> · author Caption: A musical instrument that turns a phone keyboard into a playable, shareable score. It is open-source, lives at a web address, and reached the front page of Hacker News — a tool built for other people to depend on and make their own work with. [48 words]
4. **Whistlegraph (live, social drawing)** — *The Longest Whistlegraph Ever (so far), 2022, New Museum* · <URL> · co-creator, performer Caption: Live, social drawing performed with Camille Klein and Alex Freundlich at the New Museum. It treats drawing as a real-time public act — the performance-and-community lineage behind building tools people gather around and play together. [39 words]

(Pick the 3–4 strongest.)